

The Baron of Ardaithe Campaign - Group 2

Group 2 - Session 1

As if sealed off from the world the tattered, wrinkled cloth cover on the wagon shrouds the wooden benches inside in shadow. A single tear in the cloth reveals a ray of golden morning light, illuminated inside Gichisi Beikuwen reads various notes about the wildlife of this area and specific details every ranger should know about the area around Ulstead.

With their back against the front of the wagon Errias sits thinking about the 3GP reward for investigating the source of the increased monster attacks near Ulstead, it's increased from 1GP; they worry that the Isle Guard's recruitment for help was vastly ignored and even ridiculed. The messengers and posters were met with townsfolk verbally accusing the Isle Guard of being lazy. Opposite Errias, kneeling on the floor of the wagon, Gifu sharpens her iron daggers. A jarring juxtaposition erupts in the wagon as Gifu starts to ramble about the Seven Spires:

- *"You know, one day I want to get a set of real nice daggers. Fancy ones- colour co-ordinated even. Some people name their blades- I think it's more for swords but if the daggers are nice enough, I think it'll be a nice flair! I'd call them the Seven-Stabbers, you know, like the spires! Do you know?"*

Gichisi and Errias look puzzled at Gifu and Gichisi remarks:

- *"I have no idea about the seven spires"*

Before another word can be said Gifu erupts:

- *"Okay, okay so they were these seven towers in Suluk, they're for sure the best parts of the story. So, two of them were made from green stone and two of them are made from blue stone, and then the last ones would be sort of boring because they were just white, but they were made of moonstone which makes them so much better than marble. They, uh, weren't very durable though since the Faceless Emperor destroyed them all by himself. It's such a shame, though, since there were all these cool treasures inside. There were fountains and sculptures, even the floor had a mosaic, and the ceiling was painted! All that art! Lost! Oh, and the gems. I wouldn't mind some of those either. So, I guess the Seven-Stabbers should be used to take treasure too. Hah, I should fight a load of sorcerers with them and take all their stuff, see how they like it done to them instead."*

Gifu suddenly remembers she's in a wagon with a wizard and nervously apologises...

- *"Oops. No... no offence?"*

A sudden jolt rocks the wagon and the wooden frame creaks and groans, the Isle Guard shouts out from the driver's seat

- *"We've arrived! remember to report back to Ulstead Guard Hall for your reward."*

As they leave the wagon the golden morning sun dances across the ripples on the lake. The small waterfall at the north of the lake gentle trickles creating an aura of calm.

The whimsical energy is broken as a whip crack echoes through the peace and the Guard Wagon creaks as it starts to leave Estria Lake.

A few moments before...

Raonya Stijhart determined to get revenge on the goblins that attacked Melleana (his great friend); full of energy despite travelling for days from Faelyn, comes upon the glistening lake waters that shine almost like crystals. The trees that once obscured his view reveal a group of misfit adventurers and an Isle Guard wagon heading away from the lake. Curious by this sight he walks up to the group and begins to inquire about the situation.

The group learn of the goblin attack that crippled Melleana's and the reward of 3GP is mentioned. The misfit group decide to join together and investigate the lake. As they look around, they notice an abandoned rowboat sitting on the lake shore, through the waving leaves and bushes across the lake you see a haunting reminder of the dangers of travelling outside of villages, town, and cities. A deserted camp torn by claws of a monstrous creature.

Near the battered campsite a fruit tree stands tall and proud. Errias notices the ruined mossy walls of an old building reveal themselves at the base of the surrounding trees.

After a discussion the group decide to investigate the rowboat drawing closer, they see three seats, on the front seat is a rope used to tie the boat off, on the second seat a metal hook with a loop to attach rope to at one end. On the third seat, a broken oar rests, it is unclear how the oar has broken.

Raonya decides to take the splintered oar shaft and attaches it to their pack. Gichisi realises they could craft a grappling hook from the rope and hook and after discussing it with Gifu they decide to tie the rope to the hook. A short discussion unfolds about using the boat in the lake, but the depth of the water and the broken oar would make it nearly impossible to control the boat out on the water.

The party follow the path around the lakes edge towards the horrific camp, As they near the tall fruit tree Gichisi recognises the fruit hanging from it as dragonapples, it reminds him of his hometown. It's beautiful crisp red colour makes his mouth water, and he remembers its fresh taste. Although distracted by the dragonapple tree.

As the party continue towards the campsite a campfire still with embers and ash within reveals itself. Next to the campfire is a broken shortsword and a broken crossbow that are far too damaged to salvage. The torn, bloodstained cloth of the tent is clinging to the wooden stakes and what appears to be monstrous claw marks are visible. A blood trail leading past the dragonapple tree and towards an old, dried up well then follows the walls of the ruined house. Lodged into the stone brick wall between the well and the dragonapple tree a crossbow bolt sticks out between the cracks of the stone, there's no sign of blood on the bolt. As the party draw closer to look, they notice the blood trail lead to a collapsed wall at the corner of the house and leading into the ruins further.

Feeling sceptical they decide to try and lure any monsters out that may be hiding in the ruined manor house. Gichisi masterly draws his longbow back and fires a single arrow over the wall and with a thud it embeds itself into the wooden flooring of the ruins...

Complete silence follows and an eerie air descends onto the group. Cautiously they enter the ruins past the crumbled mossy wall, entering what appears to be a continuous hallway surrounding a main hall which was most likely used to host dinner parties or used as the restaurant area of a tavern. Entering the main hall, the wooden floorboards creak and groan as if a titan was mumbling. Errias observes the trail leading to a broken trapdoor in one corner of the room.

Distracted Gifu's eyes light up as in the centre of the room are two chests, slightly weathered but intact, both are closed and appear to be missing locks. a rotting, ragged blue carpet with ornate golden patterns is at their feet welcoming them into the main hall.

The party decide to check the chests in case there's some sort of riches or exotic weapon available..

Raonya using his quarterstaff lightly taps the top of the chest worried it may be trapped or rigged. As Raonya reaches down to hit the chest the morning beams break over the wall of the ruins illuminating the hall, four orange eyes reflect in the sunlight and suddenly the chest opens revealing 2 rows of sharp teeth. Anyone inside the hall immediately recognises the monster as a mimic.

The mimic lunges off the floor towards Raonya and misses, it's jaw clamping shut with a snap sound; it retreats to some rubble.

A battle ensues and although the mimic had the jump on Raonya, it was unable to land a hit on any party member. Raonya's frostbite spell froze the mimic and Gichisi's arrows wore it down. Gifu finished it off with a flurry of attacks with their daggers.

Defeating the mimic, the party cautiously decide to head down the trapdoor, Gichisi and Gifu head in first and take a look around the dark, cold, damp cellar. Heading down the creaking steps, into what is assumed to be a wine cellar. With the little light entering through the trapdoor, Gifu notices the blood has started to seep into the wood staining it. The trail leads behind the first pillar on Gichisi's left and attached to the pillar is a broken brass scone which would've once held torches or lanterns to light the cellar. Gichisi notices these purple flowers as fey flowers, their subtle glow provides just enough light to see in the darkest corners of the room after both their eyes adjust.

They look around for a while and Gifu calls back to Errias and Raonya to enter the cellar. Meanwhile, Gichisi investigates the blood trail and learns that a picked clean skeleton appears to be the origin of the blood trail.

As the party reconvenes, they examine the old wine cellar together. Directly in front of the party two large wooden doors standing strong separate the next section of the cellar, leant against the doors appears to be an ornate cyan sofa, torn and falling apart. Nearby a broken oak table and chair set lay disregarded on the floor. As Errias looks back towards the stairs they see empty and broken barrels and what appears to be shelving for wine bottles against the wall.

At opposite sides of the room are broken sections of stone walls revealing tunnels. At one of the sections (on the left in reference to the map) a broken barrel and explosive marks line the brick walls and stone floor. You hear echoing through the tunnels the sound of trickling water. The other broken section of wall takes a sharp turn and it's hard to see where it leads.

Raonya used a gust spell on the two wooden doors, trying to open them however they thud against something blocking the doors appearing to be jammed or obstructed by something. Realising this the party decide that the tunnel with the barrel at the entrance would be a better place to go down due to the openness of the tunnels and cave system.

As they pass the barrel, they notice what appears to be a tunnel that was likely excavated by people, it's walls lined with pickaxe marks and dynamite slots. The tunnel has collapsed, and a small stream runs through the floor before the collapsed section with soft moss growing and creeping around the rock.

Noticing a more natural looking tunnel leading to an opening Errias and Gifu suggest continuing onwards. As the party enters the opening you see the small stream splitting the area in two. Moss creeps around the cave floor and spider webs dangle from the rock walls...

A strange sound is heard above as you look to the ceiling a large shadow shape darts across the open area and retreats into the tunnel (roughly 30ft from where the party entered). A web shoots past Raonya hitting the wall behind, it looks extremely sticky...

Gichisi instinctively draws his bow and fires an arrow directly into the shadowy shape nicking it's side as it drops from the ceiling, Errias used create bonfire spell to summon a bonfire however as the giant spider lands onto the floor revealing it's eight thick legs and yellow eyes, it manages to jump to the side. Gifu launches an attack with their dagger running from the centre of the cave and slashes its face. The giant spider suddenly launches a web at Gifu in retaliation, but Gifu manages to avoid most of it brushing off the sticky web. Whilst the spider launches its web it climbs onto the roof of the cave and heads towards Raonya and Errias. Gichisi takes out his two shortswords and in two expert cuts slices open its abdomen before slamming his second shortsword into its head killing it.

The party recollects their thoughts, and groups up before readying to continue down the cave tunnel...